

Sports at Passover

By Harold U. Ribalow

THE PASSOVER SEASON — One of the pleasant and happy Jewish calendar events — comes just about half-way through the Jewish year, a good enough time to reflect, among other things, on the progress (or lack of it) on Jews in sports.

Each year there comes a time, a pertinent time, to discuss where we stand as Jews. This is, I think, a useful period to analyze the role and the stature of the Jew in the world of athletics.

Andy Cohen, who once was a great Jewish baseball star and then vanished into the minor leagues, recently asserted that anti-Semitism has nothing at all to do with the lack of Jewish ballplayers in the minor and major baseball leagues. Cohen is now the spokesman for all former Jewish stars who seem amazed at the paucity of Jewish athletes. But he had a reason. He said that Jewish parents prefer that their sons don't become athletes. Ruby Goldstein, the ex-prize fighter and present boxing referee, says the same thing, but adds that the kids aren't as tough as they used to be. And he sounds as if he regrets it.

Obviously, we no longer have the great Jewish stars in baseball and boxing. And events this past year make this point even more clearly. Once the domain of the Jew, prize fighting has become the kingdom of the oppressed and poverty-stricken: The Puerto Rican, the Negro and those who come from families which cannot, for one cause or another, emerge from the lower economic ladder except through something accidental like boxing.

THE RESULT? This last year there has been one big Jewish name in the ring: Alphonse Hallimi, the Algerian-Jewish fighter, a former batamweight champion. He was good, he fought well and fiercely. But he met his match in a Mexican gamecock, who knocked him out — twice, and so Hallimi more or less passes from the scene. There are no others.

In baseball, much the same holds true, with a few exceptions here and there. The most brilliant one is Larry Sherry, who faces the Spring of 1960 with extraordinarily high hopes. Last season he had his mark as a relief pitcher with the Los Angeles Dodgers and when the World Series time came around, he was the finest star of them all, a little like Cinderella. He was written about; he was given banquets and plaques and awards and huzzahs. But now that the season is about to get under serious way, he has to fight for a position on his team as a regular starting pitcher. This is what all pitchers want. But Larry's manager remembers Larry's ability as a stopper. And so we face a new drama: Will Larry Sherry decline, as reliever pitchers usually do the second time around? Or will he emerge as a new starting pitcher, a genuine star? Except for Sherry no Jewish ballplayers of stature are on the horizon. Yes, you can find a few Jewish names, but not real big ones.

EVEN IN BASKETBALL, where we have Dolph Schayes, the day of the star Jewish hoopster is about over, and don't ask why, for it is a puzzler. Jews, after all, attend colleges in high percentages and the court stars come from the college game. But apparently the Jewish boys don't grow, as a rule, to seven feet tall. And here's the rub. Wilt Chamberlain of the Philadelphia Warriors, when asked how you become a basketball star, said, "First you grow to be seven feet, one inch tall . . ." Except for Dolph, there are no Jewish stars in the professional game, and in colleges, there are fewer and fewer outstanding Jewish players. Even teams like New York University, which used to boast many Jews on the basketball roster, now attain peak performances with teams minus Jews. There's nothing deliberate about it; that's how it happens. And Yeshiva University, which had some fine small league teams in recent years, declined sharply this past season. And Brandeis wasn't heard from at all in the recent past.

Schayes, however, remains a marvel and in the basketball season just past, he broke records and won national acclaim. He became the first player to score

more than 15,000 points; he was named to the All-Star team; he was the sparkplug of his Syracuse club; and remained a headliner in the face of sensational performances of giants like Wilt Chamberlain and Bill Russell. He continued to play in every scheduled game and was deadly from the free throw line. He was a leader in rebounds and a true giant of the sport.

NOW 31 YEARS OLD, Schayes is fantastically durable in a rough, difficult sport. In his entire 12-year career, he has missed only three games all told—and his team has played in more than 800. He missed the three games in February 1952. His coach Paul Seymour tells something about Schayes' spirit when he reminds us that "Dolph's face was cut so badly in a collision that five stitches were needed. But he insisted on playing. He took a foul shot and missed by yards. Only then did he find out he was trying to play with a broken wrist." Six days later Schayes was back performing with his wrist in a cast, and he has since played in more than 575 games in a row. He is, to my mind, one of the handful of major stars in any sport—certainly in basketball.

In tennis there was once a small group of Jewish players who ranked with the best. They included Herb Flam and Dick Savitt. Today, Flam doesn't count and Savitt is an occasional player in a handful of tournaments. Professional tennis has come along in the last five or ten years, but here, too, the Jewish player has played no roll at all. Just about the same may be said for Jews in professional football. Now and again there will be one, but in no great numbers. And surely, the days of a pro season during which a Marshall Goldberg and a Sid Luckman would be outstanding, also have passed.

IT IS DESIRE which is lacking nowadays and, as we see, when it is there, it may not be coupled to ability. This is what makes sports so difficult for youngsters in our time, and Jewish kids in particular, who are faced with the long list of Jewish names on scholarship listings, and who realize, quite on their own, that learning is more important than games. And so the games suffer. Are we better off encouraging a young man to become a scientist who can work on a project aimed at going to the moon than we are in patting a fellow on the back and asking him to hit that long ball for a home run on a sunny baseball field before thousands of relaxed lookers-on?

Each man must provide his own answer to that one. Meanwhile, during Passover, we are permitted — nay, commanded — to ask questions.

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